



future are plentiful in the Tanakh, including the consultation of seers to interpret dreams such as Joseph's about lean cattle, which predicted famine in Egypt; belomancy, the shaking of arrows in a sacred quiver; and official divination, probably by casting lots. All of these divinatory activities were said to channel God's will, rather than invoke magic to enforce action upon him.

Closer to ancient Middle Eastern practices were descriptions of the *sotah* ritual—a woman suspected of infidelity drank water in which parchment bearing specific verses from the Tanakh had been

dissolved. If she was guilty, her body was said to undergo an immediate, visible change that would eventually lead to her death. Ultimately, however, the Tanakh only supports human intervention sanctioned by God, as when the Israelites reached the Jordan River on their way into the Promised Land. With God's blessing, the Ark of the Covenant that the priests carried caused the water to miraculously part and let them pass unscathed.

▲ Miraculous ascent

This Italian fresco shows the prophet Elijah being taken up to heaven in a chariot of fire, propelled skyward by a whirlwind. As he departed the earth, Elijah dropped his cloak onto Elisha—a sign that he had chosen him to be his prophet successor.